nutrition

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/40876698.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Canon Universe, Post-Canon, Canon Compliant, Cooking, Food, Catra POV

Language:
English

Series:
Part 18 of Outside of the War - She-ra canon stories

Stats:
Published: 2022-08-08 Words: 4,867 Chapters: 1/1

nutrition

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/40876698.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Character:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Melog (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Canon Universe, Post-Canon, Canon Compliant, Cooking, Food, Catra POV

Language:
English

Series:
Part 18 of Outside of the War - She-ra canon stories

Stats:
Published: 2022-08-08 Words: 4,867 Chapters: 1/1

nutrition

by n7punk

Summary

Catra always knew ration bars sucked, and she even picked up that real food was complicated in her brushes with stolen contraband and greater Etherian society over the years, but she never knew the rituals around food that most of Etheria observes, like.family dinner?
(Or, the progression of Catra's meals after the horde)

Notes

References the events of "Don't Go." I thiiiink they call the food Glimmer makes steam buns in the show? So that's what I used here because I was too lazy to log into Netflix
Most of this series is standalone and technically this is too but I do recommend reading buried/daylight before this as they were originally intended to be one fic and then went in different directions.
CONTENT WARNING: mentions of disordered eating patterns in the past.

See the end of the work for more notes

Catra's first meal outside of Horde rations is fish skewers from a port they pass through on their way back from trying to destroy the Sea Gate, but she doesn't really count it. It's her first time officially having something other than rations, and it's the most delicious thing she's ever had or *will* have for a long time, but it isn't how she imagined her first meal. The next several times aren't much better — some stolen contraband when she was Force Captain, a pitstop meal on a mission, survival food from the Crimson Waste that at least tastes better than rations, *dinner with Horde Prime* — and in the end, she decides her first meal outside of the Horde should be the first meal she has after she has left it.

It's steam buns made by the Queen of Bright Moon herself, eaten on the floor of an ancient spaceship. Of course Adora has to ruin that, too, her casual comment about Catra joining the Rebellion souring her stomach and forcing her to turn away — from her, from the meal, from the light. Despite the small breakdown that followed — and maybe partially influenced by how she lifted up afterwards — Catra still considers it her best first meal from all the reasonable candidates. It's not her first time trying real food no matter how she tries to define it, but the food was good and Adora was there, which is kind of how she always imagined her first real meal would go.

Glimmer's cooking isn't superb — though Catra could never insult it no matter how many better dishes she tries after the rations she grew up on — but there isn't a lot to cook with on the ship anyway, so they end up eating rations for the most part. It turns out there is a difference between Horde rations and what other people consider survival food — something she probably should have guessed after the Crimson Waste — and it's still a vast improvement, even if Catra feels unsure every time they gather on the bridge to split up what they have, the group chattering as they eat.

It isn't that different from going to the cafeteria in the Horde, but it feels like it. By the end Catra was rarely doing that, anyway. She would grab rations — or contraband, if she cared enough to have something edible — and keep working as she ate. Sometimes she

wouldn't think to eat at all. Sometimes she would think of it, but she still wouldn't. Absorbed in her work, too busy to slow down, she told herself. She could do it later. It was a waste of time. They were so *close*.

Suddenly sitting surrounded by friends – almost-friends, ex-enemies, she doesn't *know* – while someone divides up the rations they have and takes a count to make sure they have enough for the trip back is a violent change. On Horde Prime's ship, she always tried to eat quickly because she never quite trusted food would be given again soon. Sometimes the food would be worse than brown ration bars and sometimes it would be a delicacy. She isn't sure Horde Prime knew which category a meal would fall into for her. She doubts he would have cared considering all the clones subsisted off a nutrient slurry.

At least if there's one other person adjusting to dinners on the ship, it's Wrong Hordak. He seems to take to them with ease, though. He never storms out of one, or has to hide behind the incinerator to avoid one despite how it's too hot to huddle against. For the most part, she hasn't minded the meals. She doesn't know if Adora said something to the others or they're just *nice* and know to leave her alone when she gets quiet, but on the days where she doesn't know how to hold her tongue back from being biting, everyone continues on around her and doesn't bother her.

She was fine this morning, but she isn't now. Her neck keeps itching. She can't take her hand off it, wrapped around the scarring tissue to assure herself there's nothing there. She thinks if she walked out onto the bridge right now she would walk straight into dinner with Prime again. She's trying not to hide in general, but this isn't her first time disappearing into the depths of the ship and it won't be the last.

When she thinks dinner should be over, she does her best to sneak back to the small room that has remained hers. The others all sleep together – except Entrapta, who seems to just fall where she stands in the middle of working the same way she did back in the Horde – but they haven't invited her to join them. Adora promised to try giving

her space when she needed it and Catra is pretty sure letting her have her own room is part of that. It's only the brig, anyway, and it's definitely the most comfortable place on the ship for her given its proximity to the engines. Their sounds and gentle warmth are soothing.

When she walks in, there's a bag of rations sitting on her pillow. She stands in the doorway, her tail flicking from side to side and ears twitching. If she felt more attached to the space it might feel like a violation, but given the things that have happened in here, it just feels sweet. She isn't sure if she feels up to eating right now, but she also doesn't want to miss a meal entirely. Cautiously, she steps all the way into the room and sniffs the air.

Entrapta. Well, that's interesting.

--

Once they return to Etheria, eating goes a lot like it did on the ship. Mostly they all eat at once, scattered around their encampment in small clusters. The food is better – they have some ingredients on hand and Perfuma can grow them fruits and vegetables – but it's also very different. Catra is used to rations. She doesn't know what to do when someone hands her a fruit and everybody around her sets to peeling it in a specific way that they all just *know*.

Adora notices. Of course she does. She said at that first meal that she was excited to show Catra food outside of rations, but it's hard not to notice when Catra bites into a fruit and nearly cracks her teeth on the hard pit she didn't know would be in the center. Sometimes Catra would purposefully sit away from Adora on the ship if she was feeling overwhelmed, but she quickly finds herself sticking to Adora's side so that Adora can quietly show her how to do it when something

that needs to be eaten a specific way comes up without drawing too much attention from the others.

She really isn't alone in her confusion and caution at meals now , at least, because Melog has been living off the vestiges of Kytis vegetation for years and doesn't know any of Etheria' s food. Catra can dismiss her caution as Melog's when she is handed something.

"Y ou sure this is safe?" Catra asks, holding out the strange spiny vegetable she was just handed to Melog for them to inspects. Melog sniffs it and blinks at her. They have no idea.

"I mean, I guess I don't, but I can heal them if it isn't probably? It tastes really good. I know Swift Wind can eat it too, so I don't know why it would be a problem for you guys," Adora says, using the knife Netossa handed her to start cutting off the spines. That makes a lot more sense than just eating it straight. Catra wasn't given a knife, but she doesn't need it. She slides out her claws and starts copying Adora.

"Make sure to dig in a little at the base. The spines are inedible or at least, like, really bitter. Aside from that you can eat the whole thing," Adora tells her, glancing over as Catra works. Catra acknowledges her with an ear twitch, eyeing the little pits Adora has left all over the vegetable surface as she worked. Catra goes back and makes sure to carve a little more away. Adora sets to flaying hers once she has the spines removed. The first chunk she cuts of f, she holds out to Melog. Catra watches them crane their head over her lap and sniff it.

t reminds them of a food Catra has never had, but through Melog she can taste it. They take it cautiously from Adora' s fingers as Catra cuts her first slice. She doesn't know if that is because they are unsure of it or if it's so they don't bite Adora' s fingers on accident. She's been through far worse. Melog's ears twitch as they bite down on the surprisingly crunchy vegetable. The taste surprises them compared to the smell, but they like it. They mew approval. Catra smiles to herself as she takes her own bite.

Not bad. Glimmer doesnt seem to like it – Catra can see her wrinkling her nose occasionally between bites where she and Bow are sitting off to the side – but Catra would put it on par with her cooking.

"I love these. I think it's cuz they're kinda bitter," Adora says next to her, mouth half full as she crunches on her own piece. Catra swallows and snorts, elbowing Adora a little.

"Shadow Weaver's gonna yell at you for being gross," she says, because she used to say it all the time when they were kids and Adora would talk with her mouth full. Shadow Weaver is here, lurking somewhere on the other side of the hideout and brooding probably, but she tends not to approach them. Catra is pretty sure the others are running interference. The Castaspella woman definitely is. If Shadow Weaver walks towards Adora, or Catra, or Glimmer, or Bow-

Well, she has a very stern glare and she isnt afraid to use it. Adora wrinkles her nose and then predictably opens her mouth to show Catra its contents. It's disgusting and childish and despite herself Catra lets out an almost shrieking laugh and shoves at Adora's shoulder. Adora grins as she finishes actually chewing and swallowing, checking Catra with her shoulder in return. Melog, not wanting to be left out, butts Adora's lap with their head. Adora misinterprets them.

"Okay, okay, I'll get you another. One second," she tells them, chuckling to herself as she cuts off another slice and holds it out for them. Melog takes it just as delicately as last time. For some reason, watching Adora feed Melog – or maybe just the aftermath of joking around with her – makes Catra's cheeks warm. After the food was handed out, everyone spread out around the hideout, but she knows her laugh drew attention even if there is no one right next to them. She tries to ignore how warm her fur feels.

She cuts off another slice and takes a bite, keeping her gaze fixed down on her food. She pretends she doesnt feel the eyes on her.

--

They eat whatever they can on their first morning back in Bright Moon, scrounging the pantries and then settling into meetings to figure out their next steps. They run around all day, but by evening, the castle is put together enough for a proper meal and Catra realizes for the first time that she might not have had a dinner this entire time.

She has eaten, of course, some good food and some bad – though the only things she can categorize as truly bad were on Prime's ship because even Rebellion rations and scrounged food from the woods beats ration bars – but it turns out there is more to a meal than what you eat. She walks into the dining room and very nearly straight into a flashback. She thinks the only thing that saves her is that half the Alliance made their way here before her and the room is filled with joyful chatter.

It's a different environment than the dinner with Prime was and nothing about Bright Moon could really be compared to that place, but it's a long table laden with food she doesn't recognize and it's close enough to leave her unsure as Adora leads her to a spot near the head of the table. She snags a chair for Catra along the way from a gap between Scorpia and Netossa, not hesitating to push what Catra assumes is Adora's usual chair over and squeeze the two chairs in together. Catra is blushing as she drops down into her seat. Melog shrinks and hops into her lap as Adora sits between Catra and Bow, their arms brushing from how close the chairs are shoved together.

They get a few glances and greetings – Adora dragging the chair over was *loud* – but no one's eyes seem to linger. Catra is grateful, because she has no idea what is in front of her. Adora doesn't hesitate, immediately reaching for the closest dish – some kind of

layered thing in a tray – and cutting of f a slice for herself. She glances up at Catra as she does so.

"Food is super complicated and Im still learning about it, but the staf f know what they're doing. Im not allowed to cook because Ialmost blew up the kitchen when Itried. Idont know if youll like this, but I promise everything on this table is better than ration bars," Adora says, prodding the dish over to Catra. Catra takes the weird wedge knife she just saw Adora use and carefully stabs the bottom of one of the slices, scooting the empty plate in front of her – which is smaller than Adora's, she notices, a lot of the places at the table have two different plates for some reason – closer so she doesnt drop the slice on the table.

"Iforgot we're going to have to teach Catra about real food. W ait- Did we ever teach Scorpia?" Glimmer says, her brow wrinkling. She' s sat across the table from them, next to Micah. Micah glances up, his brow furrowed. He seems confused, but Adora told Catra that he was eating bugs when they found them, so he cant judge her . Catra hasnt done that since she was a little kid, and it was mostly to gross Adora out.

"Perfuma took charge on that one. They were working on it until we had to abandon Bright Moon and just switched to whatever we could manage," Bow replies as Adora stands up and reaches over to grab another serving plate. At least Catra knows a sandwich when she sees one. They're a weird shape, and small, and she has no idea what all the little saucers of vaguely yellow liquid around them are, but she at least knows how to eat it.

"So she knows about health food and like three pastries. W e're going to need to have an intervention," Glimmer replies as Adora shovels five of the little sandwiches onto her plate and takes one of the saucers. She doesnt ask Catra first this time, passing her three of them before pausing and looking up to send her a questioning look.

"That' s fine, Adora," Catra tells her , rolling her eyes. "There' s already more food on her plate than she thinks a normal meal in the Horde

would be, but it's hard to know when all the food she has had so far filled her in different ways. Adora shrugs and stands to walk a few seats down, passing the serving plate off to Frosta, who has her hand in the air and is making a grabby motion. There are other dishes going around too. Not nearly as many as Prime had set out, the food limited to a few large trays that everybody is taking from, but it's very different from the quieter meals they had on the run.

Everyone is here and they're all talking loudly in between bites, multiple conversations going that random people keep getting pulled into or dropping out of. By the time that Adora has made her way back with a vegetable in each hand – at least Catra thinks they're vegetables, but she doesn't recognize them and they're cut down the middle with some kind of filling – Catra has already been pulled into a conversation with Glimmer that mostly feels like she's being quizzed on what she's eaten.

Luckily that gets diverted by Micah asking why Catra isn't used to food. Unluckily that is a big question, but it's indicative of the entire night and leads to the realization that slowly dawns on Catra as they eat: dinner isn't just about eating in Bright Moon.

In the Horde, the cafeteria always had some chatter to it and people would talk a bit as they ate, but usually just about their current assignment or the latest raid. Maybe they would joke around with their friends, but everybody knew not to be too loud, say too much, take too long, or be too vulnerable when everybody else was around. Tonight, Catra watches everything from pleasant chatter to prying questions to Micah *tearing up* and being comforted when he takes a bite of a dish he hasn't had in twenty years and is suddenly hit with emotion.

Like everything else, the princesses have to bring emotion and vulnerability into their meals. There's no escaping it in the Rebellion. As the dinner drags and Catra finds herself caught between having fun and being overwhelmed, she wonders if there will ever be a time where she can curl away and just be or if she is going to spend

every meal – every *day* – trying to navigate the minefield of *positive social interaction* that she has found herself in.

Absorbed in her thoughts and not really paying attention, Catra tries to drink from the small saucer Adora brought over and accidentally draws attention to herself when Adora scrambles to stop her and explain what dipping sauce is. At least it's a reprieve from the more emotional conversations, even if it makes Catra's pride burn to hear Perfuma and Frosta giggle at her. Glimmer outright laughs, but she's allowed to without it hurting too much.

The only thing that stops Catra from shutting down completely is when Glimmer starts telling the story of when Adora almost made the same mistake, was corrected, and then drank it anyway just to see. Adora laughs along and shrugs. She doesn't seem bothered at all. Catra is trying to be like that.

She isn't Adora.

--

They don't always have to eat with everyone. Catra and Adora have an almost-fight about it – well, about Catra being unwilling to talk about how overwhelming dinner was, mostly because it was *good* too, just draining – but Catra feels more settled with the knowledge they can just grab something from the kitchens sometimes. For a few days, she manages. Catra finds that breakfasts, and lunches when they have them, are usually calmer and more casual, people coming and going at their own pace, but dinners are more defined. It's the end of the work day and nearly everybody shows up.

Adora says they're just celebrating having the opportunity to do so again and they will get smaller as time passes, but it hasn't happened yet. It takes a few days before Catra has an evening

where she just can't drag herself through the social interaction of dinner. She needs to refuel and then collapse in a heap with Adora. Really she just needs to climb into Adora' s arms and ignore everything else for approximately ten hours, but Adora will turn into a drama queen if she doesn't get food first, so they have to stop by the kitchens.

"I haven't even seen the kitchens yet," Catra prods shortly before when they should start heading to dinner. She actually did see them, briefly, when they all raided the pantry on that first day, but they were in disarray. She has been eating food she doesn't understand from an unknown source for days. Adora turns to her with that shining, proud expression she wears every time she decides that Catra has made progress and takes her hand, steering her down a path that definitely doesn't lead to the dining room.

The kitchens don't actually look that dif ferent than they did when she passed through them before. They are cleaner and have a buzz of activity to them as a few chefs move between stations, platters of food being prepped and set out for a server to grab, but nothing major has changed. The smell of food fills the air , some of the dishes clashing a little but the overall effect mouthwatering despite how Catra was sure she wasn't that hungry only a few minutes ago.

"Wash your hands first!" an elf orders from across the kitchen as they approach the plates, but the tone is only lightly scolding. Adora laughs and salutes as she tugs on Catra's hand and guides her over to the sink.

"Yes, sir," she agrees obediently , only dropping Catra's hand to wash. Catra watches as the elf stands over a sizzling pan while she waits for her turn. Another chef has a large pot that she is scraping a plate of chopped ingredients into and stirring gently. The room is filled with sounds as well as smells, Catra only able to recognize some of the scents on the air as familiar. She still can't name any of them, just watching as the third chef pulls a large tray out of the oven.

It's a lot, all unknown to Catra. It isn't overwhelming like dinner is – there's no expectations for her here, except maybe that her hands are clean – but it's a synchronized dance not unlike battle as the chefs move around each other to see to their various dishes, keeping them all from burning and plating them as they go. Watching the kitchen as she steps up to the sink herself, she understands why there's nothing like this in the Fright Zone. It's so much to know and so frivolous when the proper ingredients ground down can give a cadet everything they could need.

She also can't understand anyone who had this before ever leaving it behind. Shadow Weaver had this at Mystacor, surely, but Catra watched her eat ration bars like it was nothing. After only a few weeks of having real food, she can't imagine ever going back even if she doesn't understand how any of this works. Watching the chefs at work, she *wants* to understand. She steals glances at them as Adora gets them both plates and they both select a few things from the dishes that are already done.

She doesn't even know how to tell when a dish is good or bad for her – because people eat things that are *bad* for them here just for fun – much less know anything about the ingredients that go into it. Maybe it's a paranoia thing, not liking being reliant on these strangers to feed herself. Maybe the food is just that good and she wants to have more of it.

She's going to have to ask Glimmer for that food orientation soon. She wants to understand. For the moment, she turns away and sets to teasing Adora about how much she put on her plate.

--

They do actually have a formal orientation with Catra, Scorpia, and Adora – again, because according to Glimmer she didn't absorb

enough to not be a disaster in the kitchen the first time—two days later. It explains a lot of Catra's bigger questions about food in general, but it doesn't teach her how to cook. Bow steps in instead, because Adora certainly can't help and apparently Glimmer only knows how to cook one dish. They start commandeering the kitchen occasionally when they both have downtime in the afternoon. Once Catra knows a little more, maybe she'll have one of the actual chefs teach her instead, but she needs it to be someone she knows right now.

Bow is warm, and nice, and probably the most understanding person she has ever met. Unlike Glimmer, he didn't grow up with a staff and actually knows how to cook for himself. Catra feels a bit like a *child* trying to learn, but he's always encouraging. She can't imagine having another teacher. It's already frustrating enough when she burns something or almost swaps the salt for sugar. He even goes to the library and finds her a book on magical diets, teaching her for the first time ever that she has food sensitives—some of which are to food she has already tried and just didn't realize it was the reason her stomach was hurting.

"Thanks for , you know...doing this. Eating my shitty cooking and all that," Catra says as they pick apart her final product of the day with a fork. Melog didn't like it, but it turns out they have different palates and she thinks it's pretty good. She tries to thank people, but it can be hard when it's for something vulnerable. Food feels *very* vulnerable, but he has helped her with more than being able to feed herself.

She feels more comfortable at mealtimes now. She might still not know the names of a lot of dishes, but she's starting to be able to recognize what *kind* of dishes they are. She knows how to eat them and she can even pick out a few ingredients on sight. It makes it a lot easier to relax at meals and just focus on the conversation, which in itself has gotten a lot easier, especially now that Adora's prediction has come true and the gatherings have shrunk in size, if they have a formal dinner at all. Bow beams at her from across the counter .

t’s *good* cooking, Catra, and you’re welcome. Most people learn to cook over their entire life and some people are always bad at it. You’re already better than two of my brothers,” Bow promises her. He grins as she ducks her head, ears twitching and cheeks warm. To avoid replying to that, she shoves another bite into her mouth. It isn’t as good as what the kitchens usually put out, but that’s to be expected. She likes it and Melog can deal with it. She could eat this every day if she had to. It wouldn’t be balanced, but she could probably manage that by combining it with the other recipes Bow has taught her.

Technically, she knows enough to stop if this was just about making sure she can feed herself. She still says yes when Bow asks if they should meet the same time next week. She wants to know more. She wants to have options. She wants to be able to make food that makes Adora squeal in delight when she tries it like she did when she took her first bite of breakfast this morning. She wants to be able to make Glimmer those tarts she likes so much that having just one of brought her back from a meltdown last week. She wants to make crabcakes for *herself* and then to make smaller versions of them for Entrapta. She wants to be able to make Melog something they like whether or not she agrees with their palate.

Cooking isn’t about necessity anymore, if it ever was. It was easier to ask for help when she made it about being able to handle herself. She can justify making someone teach her to not be a burden, but she is learning that she doesn’t have to find excuses for the small things that make her happy, or even just less stressed. She lets herself cross her old barriers in small doses, pausing with each transgression to make sure she won’t find it punished.

She isn’t ready yet to ask Bow how to make any of the sweet things that so many of her friends like and none of them should be eating, but she *will* ask him, eventually. Maybe once she has more of a handle on cooking in general. The time will come, and for now, that’s enough for her. She saves some of what Bow helped her make and brings it to Adora, smiling to herself as Adora takes a bite and gives

her a thumbs up. They had better food just a few hours ago, but Adora happily eats what Catra gives her, and when she finishes she kisses Catra's cheek and says she's so impressed with her.

Catra deflects by saying it's really easy, Adora's just bad at it. Adora yelps with indignation and they end up tussling on the floor as Melog leaps out of their path. It's stupid, and childish, and them. It makes Catra laugh enough for Adora to be able to win, pinning her down and grinning victoriously down at her. Catra, when she has caught her breath, leans up and kisses her. She tastes like a little too much salt and not enough herbs, but Catra will work on that next time.

It's nice. It's not necessary, but it's nice, and that's enough.

End Notes

There's a secret scene for this over on my tumblr that doesnt really fit with the narrative of the fic but. Iwanted to write it lmao. It's very short.
Miiiight come back and add a chapter to this at some point specifically about Micah teaching Catra to bake (it's a headcannon of mine that first showed up in 'at beck & call') but I couldnt get into his character when Iwas working on this so Im just going to leave this as a one shot for now . Subscribe if you want. Or just subscribe to the OotW series because that will alert you to the update should Iever do it. For some reason Micah's really tricky for me. Probably just because we dont see a lot of him and he has such Good Bi energy but IKNOW there's so much trauma in there.

Please drop by the archive and comment to let the author know if you enjoyed their work!